

Traditional Weaving process of the Bodo's such as

1. Ginning

The ginning is first pre weaving process that the cottons seed are dried and cleaning off by using a wooden device after collection from the plant. It is known as *Neotha hwnai* among the Bodos. In this process, consists of two vertical wooden posts and fixed to a flat piece of wood. Then two wooden rollers fitted on it, which revolves in opposite directions. By left hand, the operator moves the crank and the machine is feeds by right hand with cotton. The seeds, dust, leafs are extracted from cotton through this process.

2. Spinning

After sizing, the boiled thread fitted on a *danganatha* (big size reel) for dried. The skein of thread wound at a stretch and then removed from the reel. The skeins of thread then spread on one pair of *gonsi* (flat long split bamboo) and let dry in the sunshine. When the threads are dry, these fitted on *chwrkhi* (small size reel) for spinning. The *chwrkhi* placed on the ground and then the threads are spins around it from the zenther (spinning wheel). Usually, it makes the thread rounds bigger, which is convenient for weaving and removes the knots of the thread. Then the threads spun again into smaller spools called the Bobbin. The zenther runs by single-handed woman who spins the thread into the wheel with one hand that other hand used for wrapping the thread into the spools. The Spinning or winding is known as *khundung thunnai* in Bodo.

3. Reeling

Among the Bodos both rearing and reeling operations are traditional techniques. The reeling has mostly done on the mulberry cocoons. Firstly, the cocoons boiled in a vessel with water by fire or softened by steam. Number of selected cocoons are kept floating on the surface of water. After over the process the cocoons packet by leaves of *tharai* (*Curcuma rubescens*) and followed by pressed with some heavy weight to removes the water completely. The cocoons are bring out from packet after 5 to 6 days and washed thoroughly to make it ready for reeling. After completion of this process, the cocoons gradually started to reel by the women folk on her left hand by right palm.

4. Sizing

The sizing is a pre weaving process, which is unique technique of handloom weaving. Sizing is a coating of lubricate mixture of natural ingredients containing like – rice powder, maize, wheat flour etc. which is overlap on the surfaces of the yarn and it makes the yarn strength, rounder in shape and uniform in diameter. The sizing processing called *Maidi hwnai* among the Bodos. During the process of sizing, ingredients are mixes in a big tube and boiled it with hot water. The process is carries out by the skilled weavers in the

village. The yarns then treated in the hot sizing solution and care has taken to see that the application of size is satisfactory. The special brushes used to spread the boiled threads and dry the starch on the yarn. Eventually, depending on the warp length, three to four persons are required to carry out sizing process. However, while preparing muga or eri yarn for weaving, the threads are soaked for 1 to 2 hours in a light warm hot water, but never boiled. For fine and strong yarn, the traditional sizing process is necessary.

5. Winding

This process is necessary that the yarn tread convert to a suitable form to make it convenient to prepare the warp. As using of traditional techniques, the method widely acceptable amongst the Bodo weavers and they are winding of yarn on bobbins (for warp). The swrkhi (winding drum wheel) can be use to wind weft yam on pirn.

6. Warping

The warping is the third stage of the weaving techniques after sizing and spinning. Specially, the process involves transferring yarn from several of tubes, cones or cheeses positioned on the creel onto a gandwi (warp beam). It requires numbers of bobbins and then bobbins are placed on a huge wooden made frame creel. After fitting the bobbins in creel, the ends of the bobbins passed through the hank frame. The length of the warp is depends on the circumference of the drum, reed and number of bobbins fitted on creel that the process is known as Ji Swngnai in Bodo.

7. Beaming

The reed is move carefully after denting towards the warp and transferring the warp sheet into weavers beam. In this process, a round bamboo stick with the strands of yarn passes through the reeds and sheet of threads is placed in the grove of beam and wound with a rope that known as phannai in Bodo.

8. Looming

The technique of looming process is consists of drafting, denting and heald knitting for proper fitting up of warp on the loom that to complete the necessary arrangements for weaving. Drafting- This process is known as Nw khonnai in Bodo. Traditionally, the white strong cotton thread used for drafting. The beam is places on the floor at the same level against two posts and tightly fixing it with two temporary bamboo posts. It helps to keep the yarns in parallel balance that the drafting process completed properly. The Baleb (flat bamboo sticks) used as lease-rods and keep upward in the warp for causing a slight opening on it. The drafting is done with the help of Nw hasung (a cylindrical bamboo pipe) by heald passed from right to left. Denting- The denting is known as khainai in Bodo. It is a traditional weaving technique of Bodos. The

warp threads drawn through the dents of the rashw (reed) with the help of a hook and the yarns placed on a gonshi (a round bamboo stick). Heald- The heald is a most important component of a weaving. It is the processing of yarn in the loom with the help of shedding. The heald an arrangement for made to tie up the yarn with necessary connections. After completed all the mentioned process, the warp fitted to the cloth beam then it become ready for weaving.

9. Weaving

The weaving has started after sizing, spinning, warping, denting, beaming and drafting or heald knitting. Nevertheless, there is some traditional process of preparing the yarn for the convenient of weaving. Generally, the Bodo women have folk used “Sal” (throw shuttle loom) and “Thati sal” or “Tat sal” (Fly-Shuttle Loom) which are the traditional type of loom. These types of traditional looms are very simple and possess with special features. We have found that the looms consist of four wooden or bamboo made stout posts. Sometimes, betel nut tree also used as loom posts. Besides this, all related weaving implements mostly made of bamboo and wood. Usually, the weaver sits in front of a loom keeping both legs against the footrest and fixing the back strap, which is adjustable for keeping the loom in tightness. The shedding motion, the picking motion and the beating motion govern the weaving. The heald bar lifted up with the left hand and simultaneously the right hand presses the circular bamboo bar down. Then the sword placed vertically in the shed and the weft passed from the right to left side by the right hand that the shuttle picked up by the left hand. The sword has beaten the weft slowly. The weaving sword then taken out and the shuttle is passed by the left hand and picked up by the right hand. At the time of weaving, the two bamboo splits work as the first weft. This is the traditional weaving technique of Bodos. Mentioned may be made here, this traditional technique takes 30 to 45 days to completion of weaving process. We have come to know that 2-3 pairs of cloths need at least 3 days.